

Commentary on
The Myth of Sisyphus
by Albert Camus

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Foreword

Write about how Camus frames the essay as an investigation into the “absurd,” and how he rejects both religion and traditional philosophy as sufficient answers. Mention that he sets out to examine how a person should live once meaning is gone.

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Chapter 1

An Absurd Reasoning

1.1 Absurdity and Suicide

Explain that Camus begins with the central question: if life has no meaning, is suicide the logical response? Show how he argues that the absence of meaning is not a reason to die but a starting point for thinking clearly.

1.2 The Absurd Wall

Discuss how human beings desire clarity, order, and explanations, yet the world remains silent and indifferent. Camus calls this clash “the absurd,” and this section shows where that feeling comes from.

1.3 Philosophical Suicide

Write about Camus’ critique of philosophers who escape the absurd with leaps of faith (like Kierkegaard or Jaspers). He thinks turning to God, transcendence, or hope is a way of avoiding reality — a form of “suicide” of the mind.

1.4 The Absurd Freedom

Explain Camus' conclusion that once we accept life has no ultimate meaning, we become truly free. Without hope, we gain a new kind of freedom, responsibility, and intensity in living.

Chapter 2

The Absurd Man

2.1 Don Juanism

Write about Don Juan as an example of someone who lives fully without seeking lasting meaning — he seeks “quantity” of experiences, not “quality” or eternal commitments.

2.2 Drama

The actor becomes a symbol of the person who lives many lives but owns none permanently. This section shows how embracing impermanence aligns with absurd freedom.

2.3 Conquest

The conqueror (or rebel) represents action, risk, and engagement with the world despite its meaninglessness. Write how this figure embodies living intensely without illusions.

Chapter 3

Absurd Creation

3.1 Philosophy and Fiction

Explain how art can express the absurd but cannot resolve it. Camus argues that creative work becomes meaningful precisely because it has no eternal purpose.

3.2 Kirilov

Write about Kirilov (from Dostoevsky's *Demons*) as someone who tries to “become God” by committing suicide to prove absolute freedom — an extreme, tragic attempt to escape the absurd.

3.3 Dostoevsky

Discuss how Dostoevsky deeply understands the absurd but ultimately escapes into Christian faith, which Camus sees as another form of philosophical suicide.

Chapter 4

The Myth of Sisyphus

Explain that Sisyphus, condemned to repeat a meaningless task forever, symbolizes the human condition. Camus concludes that the right response to absurdity is revolt, consciousness, and inner freedom — “One must imagine Sisyphus happy.”

Chapter 5

Personal Reflections